

DATA 23700

Project Deliverable 1: Dataset Audit

See course schedule for the due date.

The Dataset Audit is an early check-in with the instructor or a TA to confirm that a group's chosen dataset can support their motivating question. The audit pairs a short written document with an in-person conversation during office hours. The goal is to catch untenable project ideas while there's still time to revise them, so that groups enter the written proposal with a viable dataset in hand.

Choice of dataset is the highest-leverage decision groups make about their project (see the project overview). The audit is designed to teach and assess the specific skill of *reading a dataset critically*: evaluating whether a source of data can bear the weight of the question the group wants to ask of it.

What to prepare

Groups bring a short document (roughly 1–2 pages, no strict format) to the audit meeting containing:

- **Group members:** names of all four students.
- **Motivating question:** a draft of the problem or question the group wishes to address.
- **Proposed dataset(s):** the dataset the group plans to analyze, including source, key variables, and how multiple sources will be integrated if applicable.
- **Initial exploration:** evidence that the group has loaded and looked at the data (e.g., summary statistics for key variables or relationships, a description of relevant distributions, or one or two exploratory visualizations).
- **Argument for viability:** why the data can support the motivating question, grounded in a provisional understanding of what inferences can be supported by the proposed data source(s).
- **Known gaps or limitations:** what the group has noticed that the data may not be able to do, and any assumptions or workarounds under consideration.

The document is a working artifact, not a formal write-up.

Meeting

Each group meets with the instructor or a TA during office hours to walk through their audit document. The meeting is a conversation, typically 10–15 minutes, in which the group presents their proposed direction and receives feedback. Groups should plan to attend office

hours during the first weeks of the quarter. See the course schedule for information about office hours.

To get credit for the audit, groups must submit the audit document to Gradescope (one submission per group) and attend the meeting in office hours.

Grading criteria

The audit is evaluated on:

- **Viability of the dataset:** can the proposed data meaningfully support the motivating question?
- **Critical assessment:** has the group thought carefully about the dataset's suitability, including its gaps and limitations?

The audit may be resubmitted per the standard assignment resubmission policy. Groups are welcome to visit office hours at any time to workshop project ideas outside the formal audit process.